Impact of the addition of a Community Healthcare Worker (CHW) to an interdisciplinary team to improve outcomes in specialty patients

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ABSTRACT

Background:
Social Determinants of Health (SDOH) are the non-medical factors that influence health outcomes such as access, adherence, and clinical progression. Researchers estimate that these factors influence health outcomes by as much as 30 - 80%.[1], [2]Community Healthcare Workers (CHWs) serve as a bridge among communities and are ideally positioned to impact SDOH. A novel clinical program by Walmart Specialty Pharmacy leverages a CHW to address barriers to medical and medication therapies.

Objectives:
The objective of this study is to show how the addition of a CHW to an interdisciplinary team can impact outcomes in patients with specialty conditions.

Methods:
This is a retrospective analysis that was performed in a single center specialty pharmacy over a 6-month period (November 2020 – April 2021). Eligible program participants included any patient actively filling any prescription with Walmart Specialty Pharmacy who opted into the CHW service. Patients were screened by pharmacists performing medication counseling and registered nurses performing therapeutic assessments. During counseling and assessment sessions, pharmacists and nurses asked probing questions about patients' social conditions including barriers to adherence. Patients also completed a PHQ-2 to screen for depression. Based on the results of the interviews, questionnaires, and the clinician's judgement, the CHW was alerted to make a telephonic outreach to the patient. After outreach, notes and results of the call were recorded. The interventions made by the CHW were categorized into 6 domains (listed below).

Results:
Of the 102 patients that were identified as eligible for intervention by a CHW, there were 75 (74%) patients that received resources or assistance by a CHW. The result of the outcomes were then classified into the following domains: economic stability (29%); education access and quality (2%); healthcare access and quality (28%); neighborhood and built environment (8%); social and community context (29%); and miscellaneous (3%). Additionally, the number of interventions were tracked monthly.

Conclusions:
The addition of a CHW to an interdisciplinary team was beneficial in providing assistance and/or connecting patients to resources. Due to the nature of the role, the CHW was readily able to connect and identify barriers and act as a liaison between the patient and healthcare system. Future studies should measure change in clinical parameters before and after CHW intervention.

BACKGROUND/SIGNIFICANCE

Social Determinants of Health (SDOH) "are the conditions in the environments where people are born, live, learn, work, play, worship, and age that affect a wide range of health, functioning, and quality-of-life outcomes and risk." They are the non-medical factors that influence health outcomes such as medication access, adherence, & clinical progression.

Some researchers estimate that these factors influence health outcomes by as much as 30-80%.[1], [2]Due to the complex nature of specialty pharmaceuticals and the conditions they treat, specialty pharmacies and providers have an interest in understanding & mitigating the negative impacts of social determinants of health on disease progression, comorbidities, & drug therapy management.

A study by Kibbons et al. shows that specialty patients can face many barriers to adherence such as "medication costs, administration technique, frequent monitoring, challenging distribution networks, shipping and storage logistics, and intentional interruptions in therapy because of side effects or extenuating circumstances."[4]

Community Healthcare Workers (CHWs), trained public health workers who serve as a bridge among communities, healthcare systems, and state health departments, are ideally positioned to impact social determinants of health. A novel clinical program by Walmart Specialty Pharmacy leverages a CHW to address barriers to medical and medication therapies and the results of this program are published here.

OBJECTIVES

The objective of this study is to show how the addition of a CHW to an interdisciplinary team can impact patient outcomes in patients with specialty disease states.

METHODS

Inclusion criteria:

- Actively filling any prescription with Walmart Specialty Pharmacy
- Opted into the CHW service

Exclusion criteria:

- None

Step 01 — Patients were screened by pharmacists performing medication counseling and registered nurses performing therapeutic assessments.

Step 02 — During counseling and assessment sessions, pharmacists and nurses asked probing questions about patients' social conditions including barriers to adherence.

Step 03 — Pharmacists and nurses also completed a Patient Health Questionnaire 2 (PHQ-2) to screen for depression.

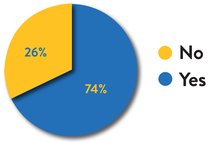
Step 04 — Based on the results of the interviews, questionnaires, and the clinician's judgement, the CHW was alerted to make a telephonic outreach to the patient.

Step 05 — After the CHW made the outreach, notes & results of the call were recorded. The interventions made by the CHW were categorized into 6 domains: economic stability; education access and quality; healthcare access and quality; neighborhood and built environment; social and community context; and miscellaneous.

RESULTS

Of the one hundred and two patients that were identified as eligible for intervention by a CHW, there were seventy-five patients that received resources or assistance by a CHW.

Patients that received resources or assistance by a CHW

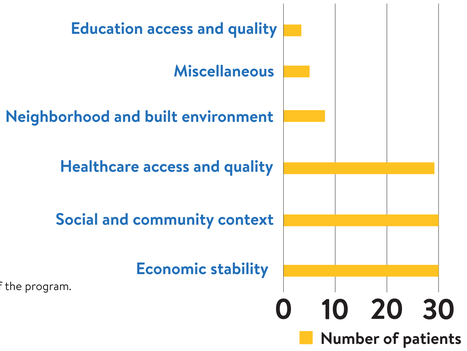


The result of the outcomes were further classified into the following domains:

- Economic stability
- Social and community context
- Healthcare access and quality
- Neighborhood and built environment
- Miscellaneous
- Education access and quality

The number of interventions were tracked monthly to see the growth of the program.

Results of outcome



CONCLUSIONS

The addition of a CHW to an interdisciplinary team was beneficial in providing assistance and/or connecting patients to resources. Due to the nature of the role, the CHW was readily able to connect and identify barriers and act as a liaison between the patient and healthcare system. Future studies can be conducted to measure change in adherence before and after an intervention by the CHW to see if these SDOH domains are barriers to achieving optimal health outcomes.

REFERENCES

[1] https://www.who.int/health-topics/social-determinants-of-health#tab=tab_1
[2] Bradley, E.H., Elkins, B.R., Herrin, J. and Elbel, B. (2011) Health and Social Services Expenditures: Associations with Health Outcomes. BMJ Quality and Safety, 20, 826-831. http://dx.doi.org/10.1136/bmjqs.2010.048363
[3] https://health.gov/healthypeople/objectives-and-data/social-determinants-health
[4] Kibbons, Amanda M., et al. "Pharmacist Interventions to Improve Specialty Medication Adherence: Study Protocol for a Randomized Controlled Trial." Drugs - Real World Outcomes, U.S. National Library of Medicine, 21 Sept. 2020, www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC7503429/#:~:text=Specialty%20medications%20have%20unique%20challenges,side%20effects%20or%20extenuating%20circumstances.

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Our sincerest thanks to the entire Walmart Specialty Pharmacy team for their dedication to engaging patients, building relationships and influencing outcomes for our patients. Special thanks for continuing to create moments of care that change lives for everyone, everywhere.

Authors of this poster have nothing to disclose.

Walmart Specialty Pharmacy